Exemplar: The A-Grade Kill — Team Klausurly (M07 → Demo Day)

Synthetic exemplar — realistic but invented. This is the artifact the rubric means by "a rigorously argued kill can be an A." Read it even if you never kill.

One-page autopsy (submitted week 8)

What we believed (M02): Students will pay for AI-generated practice exams in their professor's exact style. **What we tested, in order:** 14 Mom Test interviews (M03) → landing page, threshold ≥8% signup: got 13.4% ✓ (M04) → prototype, 41 users, strong exam-week usage ✓ (M05–06) → **the wallet: €4.99/exam, pre-committed threshold "≥3 buyers in first 10 live asks" → 0 of 9 paid** (M07 week). **Cause of death:** free-alternative gravity. The pain is real but fully absorbed by free substitutes (forums, Moodle, ChatGPT). Usage-love ≠ willingness to pay — our own glossary called it: 41 fans, 0 customers. **The B2B pivot test (pre-committed):** 10 named tutoring schools asked in 5 days → 2 replies, 0 interest ("we ARE the content"). Kill line triggered. **KILLED 16.05, announced in check-in. What the €0 test would have been in week 2:** asking the 14 interviewees "have you ever paid anything for exam prep?" — we had the answer (2 of 14) in our own Interview Log and didn't weight it. Cost of learning this: 6 weeks. It's in the log for the next idea.

The Restart Ramp (same week)

Kill Ritual done (this page). 48h re-ideation from OUR artifacts: the Fachschaft distribution channel (12.9% CTR) was the strongest asset we had — stronger than the product. **Concierge restart:** "Klausur-Countdown" — a paid, human-curated 4-week exam-prep sprint for Statik (the exam with the loudest panic quotes), €29, capped at 30 seats, sold through the same channel.

Outcome by Demo Day

23 seats sold × €29 = **€667 verified** (Stripe dashboard, zero social-graph buyers — Fachschaft channel is outside the rubric's exclusion) · 19 of 23 completed · 11 said they'd buy the next one · second cohort waitlist: 31.

Why this is an A trajectory (grading rationale)

Evidence quality: every claim above cites an artifact (logs, thresholds, dashboards). Decision discipline: two pre-committed thresholds honored AGAINST the team's attachment; kill announced publicly; no zombie weeks. Verified traction: €667 real revenue post-restart — less money than the top teams, more decision quality than almost anyone. Communication: this page IS the demo-day story.

The lesson to steal: the kill wasn't the end of the company — it was the moment the team stopped spending weeks on a dead hypothesis and started charging for a live one.